

With Oracle Sales Online, you can analyse sales forecast data at all three levels—geographic, deal and product

as team scheduling. There's a Task List that gives your team a comprehensive view of what's to be done. You can schedule activities, individually, or for your workgroup.

The software displays the availability of your team at a glance. When you schedule a group activity, a notification appears on each team member's status bar. Users have the choice to accept or decline participation.

You can create custom Activity and History types specific to your business. For example, you could create and track "Billable Hours" as an activity type. Also, you can define a series of activities around a specific event.

Then simply schedule that series to automatically put the activities on the other team members' calendars. The activities remain linked, so when one activity moves, you are notified to move the related ones. If key information changes, a call can be scheduled for a salesperson to ensure that he doesn't miss it.

The software enables your sales team to meet its goals using inbuilt tools to track sales and make forecasts. You and your team can view all sales opportunities at once and then access, update and filter opportunities.

If you have a range of products or services, you can set them up in the Product List, and then track the product or service name, item number, cost and price. Once you have this set up, your users will consistently enter information as they sell. Scrutinising consistent information helps the analysts make better sales forecasts.

An Online Approach

Oracle Sales Online is a Web-based application for field sales representatives, resellers, and sales executives. It automates the entire sales cycle, right from account and contact management, to opportunity management and pipeline analysis, to order management.

The key functions include Customer Contact, Lead, Opportunity, Quote and Order Management. This application provides versatile tools to help sales representatives carry out their daily tasks smoothly. There is another feature called Oracle Field Sales for Palm that

Working of Sales Automation



comes with Sales Online. It enables salespersons to take all information with them wherever they go on their PDAs.

Users of Sales Online get to easily set up and save frequently-used queries, such as which top deals are in the pipeline, or which deals are closing in the next 30 days. There are Inbox Indicators, which help users visually determine data elements that are new or have been changed.

Sales Online provides sales professionals with complete customer overviews at each stage of the sales process. Before contacting customers, salespersons get to review customer information, including products installed, outstanding requests, histories, contacts, opportunities, etc. With the loads of information, sales representatives find it much easier to manage their customer accounts.

Sales Online features integrated calendars for maintaining logs of daily tasks. Users can actually keep track of all their appointments. Group calendars can help users subscribe to a common calendar across multiple users. You can even set up Public calendars to air the company goals and events, such as a common marketing calendar. Users can synchronise their business calendars with Palm and Outlook to maintain common business and personal calendars.

With Sales Online, organisations can flexibly manage forecasts. You can analyse forecast data at geographic, deal and product levels.

Time to Go Automatic, or is it?

Today's businesses are left with little breathing space. Let alone vying for the lead in the grueling race, organisations need to keep up with the breakneck pace at which more and more offices are exploring newer ideas. And when it comes to taking stock of the more-ignored aspects of business such as sales data, those who choose to continue ignoring, are simply left way behind. Sales force automation isn't magic, neither is it an overnight marvel. It is designed with a purpose—it cuts down all cumbersome paperwork, easing the sales process like never before. Are you ready? ■

ram.mohan@thinkdigit.com

aparna.krishnakumar@thinkdigit.com

The Really Mobile Workforce

Keeping up with technology, sales force automation has undergone loads of changes. With portability in mind, organisations are looking at how sales personnel can access information on a handheld. In India, companies such as Xserve India Pvt Ltd have the AnexTEK SP230. This is a handheld device with GSM Mobile functionality and GPRS connectivity running on the Intel Xscale processor and powered by Microsoft Pocket PC 2003. Ramco Systems have the Virtual Works Platform for Enterprise that promises an end-to-end solution for back office sales needs. The future of such applications looks bright with the pharma and the FMCG sector being the large customers for such applications.